



Groove on the go

**Need something compact for music and little else?
Your search ends here**

Michael Browne

The little MP3 player of yesteryear has become a converged device today that we refer to as a PMP or portable multimedia player. PMPs represent a conglomerate of features – some used often and others seldom touched. The simple principle behind developing the PMP was the need for an all-in-one device that converged the most widely used feature sets. At its most basic, a PMP is an MP3 player. Well, to be precise, a music player, since most PMPs play several audio formats in addition to MP3. But there are other features that people would want from such a device. One reason for this is that nobody wants to carry around multiple devices for specific,

individual tasks. Therefore, players with larger screens for watching movies are more or less out. While such players often end up being jacks-of-all-trades, there are some that manage to master a few.

Some people need something basic that just plays music. For others, compactness is a more important criterion for a PMP than its feature set. In fact, some people don't even require a screen. On board a dusty bus, or a crowded local, all they need is something that plays music with decent quality or maybe a device that allows them to tune in to their favourite FM radio station. For others, it's the all-important price that motivates them to choose a basic PMP rather than something with fancy features. If you fit into any of the above target audiences, then this test

was designed with you in mind and tasked with providing you a fit solution.

Many people want good audio quality and are afraid to look at lower-end PMPs for fear that a reduction in the feature set (and hence price tag) also brings about a reduction in quality. If this test taught us one thing, it was that the above assumption is totally false. Sure, the analogy of paying for what you get, does hold good. However, there is no hard-and-fast rule that a PMP with a large screen and a price tag of Rs. 8,000 would outperform a really compact PMP without a screen that costs Rs. 3,000. Another preconception that many people have is that a bigger brand equals a better product. While this rule of thumb may hold good 80 per cent of the time since bigger companies do have more resources

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